

MSc Research Project/Internship/ Practicum

Discussion and Conclusion

Self-Criticism at the Heart of Writing a Discussion Section

- For this purpose, you should **criticize the experiment**, and be honest about whether your design was good enough
- Suggest any modifications and improvements that could be made to the design.
- Maybe the reason that you did not find a significant correlation is because your sampling was not random, or you did not use sensitive enough equipment, or the data set was not big enough
- The discussion section is not always about what you found, but what you did not find, and how you deal with that.
- Stating that the results are inconclusive is the easy way out, and you must always try to pick out something of value.

Using the Discussion Section to Expand Knowledge

- You should always **put your findings into the context of the previous research** that you found during your literature review.
 - Do your results agree or disagree with previous research?
- Do the results of the previous research help you to interpret your own findings?
 - If your results are very different, why?
 - Either you have uncovered something new, or you may have made a major flaw with the design of the experiment.

Using the Discussion Section to Expand Knowledge

- Finally, after saying all of this, you can make a statement about whether the experiment has contributed to knowledge in the field, or not.
- Unless you made so many errors that the results are completely unreliable, you will; certainly have learned something.
- Try not to be too broad in your generalizations to the wider world - it is a small experiment and is unlikely to change the world.



Discussion

- **Focus the discussion on these points:**
 - **Discuss your confidence in the results (their validity and comparison with benchmarks)**
 - **The scope of the work you performed**
 - **How generalizable your work is**
 - **The strengths and limitations of your approach**

Conclusion

- **Restate your research question, your objectives and the work done**
- **State how successful you have been in answering the research question and achieving the objectives**
- **Restate the key findings**
- **Describe any proposals for future work or potential for commercialisation**